

TEAR-GASSED
Protesting farmers clash with Haryana police at Shambhu barrier, Jan. 21

REUTERS

THE KEY DEMANDS

What the farmers want

- Legal guarantee on MSP for 23 crops as determined by the agriculture ministry's agency CACP (Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices)
- Implementation of M.S. Swaminathan panel's recommendations on MSP—increase it to at least 50% of weighted average cost of production

The Centre's offer

- After the fourth round of talks, MSP on five crops—masoor dal, urad dal and arhar dal, along with maize and cotton—for five years on a contractual basis

Why the farmers rejected it

- Five years too small a window to change cropping pattern. Stabilising crop combinations take time
- No back-up plan clarity or insurance on what happens if the new crops fail

MAKING MSP A LEGAL GUARANTEE WILL ENTAIL...

- Govt agencies spent **₹1.12 lakh cr.** to procure paddy in marketing year '23. For wheat, the figure was **₹55,977 cr.** (procurement was short of target in the year)
- **₹6 lakh cr.** needed in current marketing season if Centre procures only the crops trading in mandis below MSP
- CRISIL MI&A Research estimates say **₹13 lakh cr.** needed if entire production of **16 crops** (of the 23) is procured at the announced MSP for marketing year 2022-23
- Storage capacities, distribution capability and transport have to be created on humongous scale for procured crops

On February 22, as the protesting farm unions from Punjab tried to breach the Haryana border again in Khanauri during their 'Dilli Chalo' march, a young farmer was killed in the clashes. The unions called off the protest for two days to mourn the death of 22-year-old Shubh Kiran Singh, but it was clear that their stand had hardened. The mood had changed dramatically from the evening of February 18 when the farm union leaders briefly seemed upbeat about the Centre's offer of a Minimum Support Price (MSP) for five crops.

The proposal had come after four rounds of discussions—brokered by Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader and Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann—with Union ministers Piyush Goyal, Arjun Munda and Nityanand Rai. The offer to buy *masoor*, *urad* and *arhar*, along with maize and cotton at MSP, had seemed like a game-changer for the farmers and the state. The agitating farm leaders—Jagjit Singh Dallewal of the Bharatiya Kisan Union Ekta Sidhupur (BKU Ekta Sidhupur), and Sarvan Singh Pandher of the Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Committee (KMSC)—were even fielding questions about how it could lift Punjab out of the wheat-and-paddy cycle.

The elation, though, was short-lived, as the unions backed out soon after. Pandher claimed it was because the Centre had put a 'five-year, contractual basis' rider on the offer,